



Management Performance:

Lue 03 Ecology report



Credits

No Minimum Standard

Aim

To encourage organisations to establish the ecological value of their assets and sites and improve the ecological value based on recommendations that have been made by a suitably qualified ecologist (SQE).

Question

Has an ecological survey been carried out and reported on within the last 3 years?

Credits	Answer	Select a single answer option
0	A.	Question not answered
0	B.	No
2	C.	Yes, and all of the SQE's minor recommendations for increasing the site's ecological value have been implemented on-site.
4	D.	Yes, and all of the SQE's minor and major recommendations for increasing the site's ecological value have been implemented on-site to make a significant contribution to local biodiversity, given the scope and scale of the asset
3	E.	Yes, and all of the SQE's minor recommendations for increasing the site's ecological value have been implemented on-site. In addition, off-site enhancement has been carried out within the local area, according to the SQE's recommendations for making a significant contribution to local biodiversity, given the scope and scale of the asset
2	F.	Yes, and the SQE has confirmed that there are no or very limited opportunities to improve the site's ecological value. Off-site enhancement has been carried out within the local area, according to the SQE's recommendations for making a significant contribution to local biodiversity, given the scope and scale of the asset

Assessment criteria

Criterion	Assessment criteria	Applicable Answer
1.	Before any ecological enhancement/creation is recognised, any existing ecological value must be protected and maintained in line with the Suitably Qualified Ecologist's recommendations and the mitigation hierarchy.	C – F
2.	An SQE should be independent of the organisation.	C – F
3.	Where there are no ecological features found on-site, credits can be achieved for increasing the ecological value of an area within 2km of the asset, in line with recommendations and guidance by an SQE. The size of the area must be greater than 60% of the asset footprint.	F

Specific notes

Asset type specific	
1.	Assets with no outdoor space Where there is no outside space or area to implement an ecology plan for the asset please see answer option E. It is possible for enhancement measures outside of 2km to be considered under special circumstances. If this is the case, please send details and justifications for why this cannot be done within 2km to BRE for consideration.

Methodology

Ecology Report Process

A survey and evaluation must be carried out by an SQE (or on their behalf, see below), to determine the asset site's ecological baseline including:

- Current and potential ecological value and condition of the site, and related areas within the zone of influence.
- Direct and indirect risks to current ecological value from the asset
- Capacity and feasibility for enhancement of the ecological value of the site and, where relevant, areas within the zone of influence

The survey and evaluation must be carried out at appropriate time(s) of the year for assessing the habitats and species active likely to be active on the site.

Once established, the ecological baseline should be used to determine the SQE's minor and major recommendations for protection and enhancement of the asset and its site.

The SQE should use their expertise and ecology good and best practice, to determine the appropriate scope of their survey and evaluation. As part of this they should consider any aspects that they think are relevant for the asset being assessed:

Survey:

- Determining the zone of influence for the site including neighbouring land and habitats

2. Current flora, fauna (including permanent and transient species) and habitat characteristics (including but not limited to ecological features in or on built structures)
3. Habitat extent, quality, connectivity and fragmentation
4. Recent and historic site condition
5. Existing management and maintenance levels and arrangements
6. Existing ecological initiatives within the zone of influence
7. Identification of, and consultation with, relevant stakeholders impacted or affected by the site.
8. Local knowledge or sources of information.

Evaluation:

1. Current value and condition of the site and the zone of influence in terms of:
 - a. Features including habitats, species, food sources and connectivity
 - b. Broader biodiversity and ecosystem services benefits or opportunities
2. Direct and indirect risks to current ecological value:
 - c. Sensitive areas and features on or near the site
 - d. Direct risks including those from, human activity (e.g. construction work), habitat fragmentation, and potentially harmful species
 - e. Indirect risks including water, noise and light pollution
3. Capacity and feasibility to enhance the ecological value
4. Habitat restoration and creation potential
5. Impact of the asset's current management and maintenance practices and any future developments (refurbishments, extensions etc.) such as disturbance to habitats or species using the site or asset.

The report detailing the outcomes of the ecological survey can be written by an ecologist who does not meet the Suitable Qualified Ecologist (SQE) criteria if the report has been reviewed by a SQE who confirms it:

- a) Represents sound industry good practice
- b) Has been written objectively (avoiding biased and exaggerated statements)
- c) Is appropriate given the local site conditions and scope of works proposed.

Evidence

Criteria	Evidence requirement
-	The evidence below is not exhaustive, please also refer to the 'BREEAM evidential requirements' section in the scope of the Guidance for appropriate evidence types which can be used to demonstrate compliance.
1	Copy of ecology survey, including the report.
2	Evidence that the ecology survey was carried out by a competent individual such as: copies of relevant documents, qualifications, CV or industry membership.

Criteria	Evidence requirement
1, 3	Evidence showing the recommendations for protecting or improving the asset and site's ecological value have been implemented, such as: copies of site surveys and management plans for specific biodiverse /ecological important areas on the site.

Definitions

Suitably Qualified Ecologist:

An individual achieving all the following items can be considered to be suitably qualified for the purposes of a BREEAM In-Use International assessment:

- c) Holds a degree or equivalent qualification in ecology or in a related subject comprising a significant ecology component.
- d) Is a practising ecologist, with a minimum of three years relevant experience (within the last five years). Such experience must clearly demonstrate a practical understanding of factors affecting ecology in relation to construction and the built environment; including, acting in an advisory capacity to provide recommendations for ecological protection, enhancement and mitigation measures. The relevant experience must relate to the country that the assessment is being carried out in.

Zone of Influence

Areas of land or water bodies impacted by the site undergoing assessment. These areas can be adjacent to the site or can be areas that are dependent on the site but not physically linked, including areas downstream from a site. Areas within the zone of influence can be negatively affected by changes on an assessment site but they also provide further opportunity to maximise enhancement activities.

Asset footprint:

For buildings only:

The asset is a building on its own without any associated site attached (for example, an office tower in the city centre). In this case, the asset footprint can be considered to be the area of the asset/ building only (typically the ground floor area).

For buildings located on a site:

The asset footprint can be taken as the site on which the building is situated. The boundary of the site must be drawn when either:

- a) Responsibility of management or ownership of the site changes; **OR**
- b) If a site includes multiple assets and there is a clear demarcation of the area associated with each asset, then this must be considered to be the site boundary for the asset footprint.

Additional information

Mitigation Hierarchy

The mitigation hierarchy is a method which limits the negative impacts on biodiversity during the asset's life cycle. The main principles are: avoidance, mitigation, compensation. for example, if bats are roosting in the roof, measures should be implemented to ensure their ongoing protection and avoidance of disruption in the future.